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Witchcraft, oracles and magic among the Azande

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Looked at from this aspect it is easier to understand how Azande fail to observe and define the fact that not only may anybody be a witch, which they readily admit, but that most commoners are witches. Azande at once challenge your statement if you say that most people are witches.

Notwithstanding, in my experience all except the noble class and commoners of influential position at court are at one time or another exposed by oracles as having bewitched their neighbours and therefore as witches. This must necessarily be the case, since all men suffer misfortunes and every man is some one's enemy. Every one is disliked by some one, and this somebody will some day fall sick or suffer loss and consult oracles about those who do not find favour in his eyes. But it is generally only those who make themselves disliked by many of their neighbours who are often accused of witchcraft and earn a reputation as witches.

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Keeping our eyes fixed on the dynamic meaning of witchcraft, and recognizing therefore its universality, we shall better understand how it comes about that witches are not ostracized and persecuted; for what is a function of passing states and is common to most men cannot be treated with severity. The position of a witch is in no way analogous to that of a criminal in our own society, and he is certainly not an outcast living in the shadow of disgrace and shunned by his neighbours. I had certainly expected to find, not only that witchcraft was abhorrent to Azande, but that a witch, though not killed to-day owing to European rule, suffers social ostracism. I found that this was far from being the case. On the contrary, confirmed witches, known for miles around as such, live like ordinary citizens. Often they are respected fathers

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and husbands, welcome visitors to homesteads and guests at feasts, and sometimes influential members of the inner-council at a prince's court. Some of my acquaintances were notorious witches. One of those whom I knew well was my friend Tupoi of the Amozungu clan, a prominent figure at the court of Gangura. No one would suspect, from observing his social activity in the life of his district, that Tupoi  115 is believed by every one to be a witch of long standing and of great prestige in the witch council. He is not ostracized, nor does he suffer from any disabilities. He is not even unpopular. After a while I began to hear stories about Tupoi and was surprised that such a quiet old man was believed to have committed several murders and to have brought a variety of misfortunes upon his neighbours. It was an open joke that the part of the government settlement in which he lived was unoccupied because no one wished to take the risk of living near him. It was considered wise either not to acquaint him with pending economic undertakings or, if it was impossible to prevent him from learning what was going on, to placate him and make him favourable to the undertaking. Thus a hunter would depart after game without letting Tupoi see him. When I went to shoot guinea-fowl I was generally advised to make a detour to avoid Tupoi's homestead, since my companions feared that were he to see us he would send the soul of his witchcraft to scare away the guinea-fowl. We bore Tupoi no ill will, but simply wanted to ensure that we would have something to eat. On the other hand, Tupoi was bound to know of collective expeditions, and it was usual before making them to get him, in company with other old men so as not to make it too personal, to blow water publicly to the ground in affirmation of his goodwill. People ask old men in this way to give their expeditions a blessing, but it is tacitly understood that what they request from them is that they will refrain from bewitching their hunting. One will attempt to win the favour of all old men in a neighbourhood towards large-scale hunting by distributing meat among them after a successful hunt.

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